

Heitor Villa-Lobos was born in Rio de Janeiro, and was introduced to music early in life through music-making soirees at his home. With this as his inspiration, he learned to play the guitar, cello, and clarinet, but was prevented from taking further training by the death of his father in 1899, leaving him to support the family by playing in various theater and cinema orchestras, and with the chorões, the itinerant street musicians of Rio.

Born in 1887, a year before the establishment of the First Republic in Brazil, he grew up in a country that was anxious to shake off European influence (see [box](#)). Aged about 18, he began traveling around Brazil, researching its rich musical heritage.

Striking out

In 1912, after several years traveling, he married pianist Lucília Guimarães and settled down in Rio to work as a composer. Living in this cosmopolitan city, he came into contact with some of the latest music from Europe, and through his friendship with Darius Milhaud, who was working there, he was introduced to the work of Debussy and Satie. This inspired him to make a complete break with the Germanic Romanticism that then dominated South American art music, and forge his own style.

“ Artists live with God—but give their little finger to Satan. I sleep with the angels and dream of the devil. ”

HEITOR VILLA-LOBOS